Introduction

Chelmsford College is a Further Education college offering a variety of courses, both vocational and professional courses, with c.3500 student and c400 staff members across two main campuses, providing courses to 16-19 learners, apprentices and adult day and evening courses.

The College website serves a wide array of people in the community from students & parents to local businesses and so the winning design should reflect that the website needs to appeal and be accessible to multiple stakeholder groups.

The website's primary purpose is learner recruitment. Its priority audiences are prospective 16 to 19 learners and their parents and carers, adult learners, and employers and apprenticeship partners. It also serves current students, staff and job seekers.

The college has several objectives for the new website they are to; increase applicant conversion from viewing the course page to submitting an application, deliver a mobile-first and fully accessible experience, provide search and filtering across the full course offering, to allow marketing to publish and update content directly through the use of a content management system and to meet the college's information security and data protection requirements, including for the personal data collected through the application process.

Bidders are encouraged to propose approaches that meet these objectives.

Our current website was built 15 years ago and with only minor cosmetic changes since then. We have 202 pages in total 72 static pages and 130 dynamic pages that contain job adverts, course information and newsletters. All of the content on the website is taken from our internal databases and intranet so any company tendering will need to be able to interface with those tables.

The college has a dedicated team that can handle the daily maintenance and updating of the new website but does not have the time the develop a new website inhouse which is why this project is going out to tender. We are looking for a company that will be able to build the website and then pass it off to the college to manage the day-to-day activities.

You can read more about Chelmsford College on their website: www.chelmsford.ac.uk

Instruction to Tenderers

COMPLETED PROPOSALS SHOULD BE SUBMITTED TO:

The completed tenders and any questions must be submitted via email to MilesC@chelmsford.ac.uk. **By 06/11/2026**

Suppliers should ensure that they allow enough time to submit their offer. **The College will accept no responsibility for difficulties during the process of submission and/or late or lost submissions.**

Please study the documentation carefully. If you are in any doubt as to any technical

aspects of the specification/project brief or require clarification of any part of the document, please contact the College via the emails at the end of this document.

Suppliers are required to submit competitive prices strictly in accordance with the included specification/project brief.

Suppliers must fully complete all parts of this document using the same question numbering format as used in this document. Failure to provide a completed offer submission in the required format may result in the offer submission not being considered.

Freedom of Information - In accordance with **Freedom of Information Act 2000**, from January 2005, public organisations must respond within 20 working days to valid written requests for information from anyone. The information requested must be supplied unless it falls into specified categories of information which include confidential, personal, trade secret, or information which would or would be likely to prejudice the Supplier's or the organisation's commercial interests. These categories are exemptions under which information may not be disclosed.

It will be the Supplier's responsibility to clearly state in their proposal submission any information which they regard as confidential, personal information, trade secret or may prejudice their commercial interests and to discuss this with the organisation prior to contract signing if successfully awarded the contract.

Suppliers are advised that information which falls into our agreed interpretation of the legal definition of confidentiality, personal information, trade secret or prejudice to their commercial interests may still have to be disclosed in some circumstances. You should be aware that the organisation may be forced to make information public because of an appeal by a member of the public against our initial decision not to reveal information. The public can appeal through our internal complaint's procedure and ultimately to The Information Commissioner's Office, the Government organisation responsible for enforcing the Act.

You will also need to provide with your submission a contact within your organisation to ensure that should we need to consult on a Freedom of Information request we can do this promptly. If we are unable to contact anyone to consult, we may have to release the information to ensure that we remain within the 20 working days deadline.

Suppliers are obliged to ensure that all staff that attended College premises are Disclosure and Baring Service (DBS) approved. The College may require evidence of this upon request.

Site Visit

There is no site visit planned for this tender.

Timescale

Whilst the College will endeavour to meet the timescales below it reserves the right to amend the timescales. Any timescale amendments will be made in line with PA23 timescales

- Date of Publication for Tender- 9th October 2026

- Deadline for Supplier Questions-30th October 2026
- Tenderers submission deadline- 6th November 2026
- Award of Contract –15th January 2027
- Voluntary Standstill Period – 16th January 2027
- Contract commences – 1st February 2027

We would like it to be noted that this tender will run through the Christmas period, and such will be affected by the closure of the college between Thursday 24th December 2026 and Friday 2nd January 2027

Specification

We understand that the way the website was built 15 years ago may not be the way they are built now and so we have provided a specification in 2 parts – the first section of the specification are things that the website must include or be able to do that are non-negotiable and the second section are for things we would like the website to do but currently doesn't and we are open to options and recommendations for the direction we take the website in.

All submissions must:

- Have a mobile first design philosophy
- Connect to the current College SQL tables
- Must meet the Accessibility requirements set by the Public Sector Bodies Accessibility regulations of 2018 – specifically WCAG
- Content management system to be supplied by supplier
- Website to be coded in ASP.net

  There rest of the requirements for the website are necessary but we are open to different options and solutions.

- Integration with a payment taking system

The college is looking to spend up to £50,000 on a new website we would ask that all bids come in under that value without VAT. If you know the pricing for your payment solution this does not need to be included in the build.

Demo

For the demo we have created an example data sheet that will replicate the colleges internal SQL tables we have also provided a small design brief for the types of pages we would like to see.

Each presentation will be 45 minutes we ask that your presentation is between 15 and 20 leaving 25 minutes for questions from us.

When you have submitted your tender, we will contact you with several date and time options for the demo which will run throughout November and into early December, if necessary, these slots will be first come first serve.

Due to the overwhelming number of bids on this tender we have filled all of the demo slots available in November and December this is over 30 bids, to meet the requirement for demo videos the rest of the demos will be presented to just the procurement manager those sessions will be recorded and shared with the rest of the evaluation panel and if there is need in the new year people may be called back to re-present the demo in January this is to keep to the timeline and to not invalidate the submitted tenders timelines

Price Schedule

The pricing document Appendix 3, has been created to align with the 7 stages of web design for the completion of the pricing document we would ask that you complete this document with the price broken down by stage and the expected length of time each stage should take so we have a rough idea of the project timeline.

Evaluation

This tender will have 1 stage with the price, demo and written submission marked consecutively. There will be a round of demos and then all of the written submissions will be marked. Please allow a couple of weeks for us to complete this process before you hear from us regarding the outcome of this process.

Weighting

All bids will be evaluated under the PA23 rules to determine which is the most advantageous tender. This means that the Demo, Price and Useability will be considered the for the final score of this tender.

There will be three sections bidders will score on in this tender the first is the Demo it will be worth 30% of the final scoring, the second is the Price it will be 25% of the final scoring and the third will be the Useability worth the remaining 45% of the score.

The Demo will be assessed through the planned Demonstration and questions. The Price will be assessed through final price quoted for the contract while Quality will be assessed through the questions asked in Appendix 4-Bidder answer sheet. **All questions in this document should be answered fully as they will be scored and these scored contribute to our final decision.**

The split in our evaluation criteria can be found in the table below with the complete breakdown of scores in both sections. **Bold headings** will denote the overall sections scores, whilst a non-bold heading will denote the breakdown of that section.

Section Name	Weighting
Demo	**30%**
Visuals	10%

Features	20%
Price	**25%**
Useability	**45%**
Functionality	27%
Accessibility	9%
Aftercare	9%

Scoring

The scoring for the Demo will be broken down as follows, the visual look of the demo will be weighted at 10% of the overall score and the proposed features as 20% of the total score

The scoring for the Price section will be: 25% awarded to the lowest price bid with all others scoring based on their price relative to the lowest.

The scoring for the useability section will be: 45% based on the answers to the questions on Appendix 4-Bidder answer sheet.

Each question will be reviewed and scored individually with all questions in each subsection totalling that sections score, each answer will be scored according to the table below based on the answer found on the sheet and any other permitted materials. The total scores for each section will be collated and weighted according to the table above to give the total score for the quality portion.

Score		**Scoring rationale**
0	**Unacceptable**	Question is not answered or answer is irrelevant to question/Tender
1	**Poor**	The response addresses some parts of the question but has little to no relevant supporting details
2	**Satisfactory**	The response addresses some parts of the question with some relevant supporting details or fully addresses the question with little to no supporting details
3	**Good**	The response addresses all parts of the question along with good supporting evidence providing little doubt of the bidder's ability to meet requirements. *The answer must contain a good and detailed explanation that would mean a non-expert is confident in the answer given*

Clarifications & Supplier Questions

For any clarifications in this tender, questions should be submitted to the following emails MilesC@Chelmsford.ac.uk with GreensmithM@chelmsford.ac.uk cc'd in any emails as a backup. They will need to be submitted on or before 30th October 2026, any questions submitted after this time will not be answered.

If the College is seeking any clarifications, we will email the provided contact details from the Bidder Answer Sheet and will need a response before 10th January 2027. Any points that have not been clarified before the deadline will be judged based on the original interpretation of the information.

Summary of Documents

Appendix Number	Document Name	To be returned
Appendix 1	Website Demo Brief	
Appendix 2	Demo Course Data	
Appendix 3	Pricing Document	Yes
Appendix 4	Bidder Answer Sheet	Yes